



DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE

Course Report: Political Science Analysis SK2121 Fall semester 2022

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The course Political Science Analysis (SK2121) is a core course on advanced level in political science. It is taught during the first half of the first semester on the Master Program in Political Science and forms the introduction to the program. Earlier years it was the second course on the first semester, why some changes to the course were implemented for 2018. This is the course report from the fall semester of 2022.

The idea behind the course is to present an overview of Political Science, and to make the students aware of the complexity of the subject. The course guides the students to research classics from the various research areas as well as to current research. The course applies different analytical perspectives on the various research areas, as well as different research strategies and research methods. Throughout the course, students will gain skills in critically reflected oral and written academic presentation through problem-based research overview assignments.

The course starts with an introduction to practical political theory/ rational choice followed by a discussion seminar. In order to prepare for the seminar, the students are asked to prepare a short text. This paper is preferably written two-by-two. The rest of the course is organized around four research areas – Political Behavior, Comparative Politics, Public Administration and International Politics. Each bloc consists of three parts - a “base” lecture, two lectures at the “research front” and a seminar. The base lecture presents the background and development of the research area, as well as classical theories, concepts and findings. The research front lectures presents the research front and more specifically focus on selected actual research problems, based in current research. For each research area the students are presented seminar assignments in the form of semi-selective subjects or problems which should be analyzed and discussed in a short seminar paper and discussed at the seminar, using the assigned literature. The examination of the course is based on each of these five papers and the seminars. The seminar assignments are presented in this course guide and further specified in the lectures.

Responsible course coordinator is Professor Maria Oskarson, who is also responsible for the first theme – Political Behavior. Other teachers are Associate Professor Lina Eriksson (Practical political theory), Associate Professor Georgis Xezonakis (Comparative politics), Professor Victor Lapuente (Public Administration), and Professor Adrian Hyde-Price (International politics).

The general structure of the course is that after the first week designated to introduction to the course and the moment on Practical Political Theory, two weeks are designated for each theme, with lectures in the first week and the seminar on the Friday following week.

The first discussion paper and seminar discussion are awarded 2 credits and graded with Pass or Fail. Each of the four research seminar papers are graded Fail, Pass, Pass with Distinction and awarded 3 credits each. The oral presentation earns an additional 1 credits and is graded Fail, Pass, Pass with Distinction. For grade PASS for the entire course the discussion paper, all four research papers and the oral presentation must have passed, and the student must have attended all seminars. In addition, for the grade "Pass with Distinction" either at least three seminar papers must have been graded with "Pass with Distinction" or two seminar papers and the oral presentation have been graded with "Pass with Distinction". Failed seminar papers have to be completed following the teacher's instruction in order to reach the PASS level.

For the second year, the department assigned extra resources to doctoral student, Elena Leuschner, to act as teacher assistant in Academic writing during the course. This meant that the teachers could recommend students that did not reach pass on the examine papers to contact her. This extra resource was introduced during the lecture on Academic writing, where Elena also presented herself and that she was available after e-mail appointment. Information about this extra resource was also posted on CANVAS. The interest was highest in the beginning of the course, and in total there was 17 scheduled meetings. Many of the students who contacted the T/A for guidance in Academic writing did not have the best grades but were far from struggling the most. Several students never contacted the T/A, despite recommendations from the teachers. For the teachers of the course this extra resource was most welcome, since some students otherwise tend to demand a lot of extra supervision in Academic writing.

The fall semester 2022 50 students were registered for the course, whereof 4 students were re-registered. Of these, 35 have completed the course until now (November 29), that is 70%, which is slightly lower than previous year. 17 students received the grade pass (G) and 18 students high pass (VG), which is a slightly lower average than previous year.

In 2022 the course was taught entirely on campus, whilst in 2021, the course was taught in a hybrid campus/online version due to the corona restrictions.

The students were asked to fill in the electronic SUNET course evaluation after the course was completed, and after two reminders, 23 students had replied until 29th of November, that is 45% of registered students.

Course evaluation

In total, 30 percent of the 23 students who filled in the course evaluation answered that the course helped them reach the learning outcomes to a high degree, and additional 70 percent that it did help them to a fairly high degree. The table below reports the average score on a series of assessment questions.

Table 1. Assements (average scores) 2017-2022

Assessments, average between 1 (very bad) to 5 (very good)	Score 2017	Score 2018	Score 2019	Score 2020	Score 2021	Score 2022
Overall assessment	4,36	4,52	4,33	4,33	4,65	4,30
... of lectures	4,33	4,44	4,15	4,11	4,0	4,04
... of teachers	4,59	4,79	4,42	4,38	4,47	4,35
... of the literature	4,18	4,24	4,0	4,36	4,3	4,22
... of the seminars	4,41	4,10	3,95	3,93	4,5	4,3
... of examination with research papers	4,14	4,44	4,23	4,00	4,3	4,3
... organization, the course information & use of GUL (CANVAS >2019)	4,38	4,5	4,28	4,2	4,60	4,57

Comment: I have recalculated the results from the SUNET survey in order to have the same endpoints for the 1-5 scale as earlier years when the GUL survey was used.

In general, the students evaluated the course very positively, with an average overall assessment of 4,30 on a scale 1-5 where 5 is the highest grade. This was slightly lower than last year but in line with earlier years.

The average assessments are overall very positive, and very similar to previous years. This signals that it is a mature course that has found its form in most respects. The very positive evaluation of 2021 might have been an effect that it had some campus teaching (seminars) after long periods of online teaching due to the pandemic.

When it comes to workload 74 percent of the students found it “ok”, and 26 % somewhat or much too demanding. 9 students (39%) reported that they had worked between 31-40 hours a week with the course, and 11 (47%) that they worked between 21 and 30 hours.

In the open comments, many students mentioned the structure of the course as very good, with the clear rhythm of two weeks per subfield. Some quotes can illustrate the comments:

“It is very good that we have 2 weeks to work on the paper, and that we would explore some major subjects of Political Science ! And having different professors is also a good point.”

” The course provided good introduction to Political Science, it was useful and interesting to meet different lecturers from the department and hear about their research. What is more, study pace was not too intense, had clear goals and objectives.”

“A good course with interesting areas. I like that the course covered different themes.”

Some comments were made regarding the methodological requirements, as well as the pace in the course.

"Very fast paced, felt like most modules were rushed - more time per module would probably deepen my learning experience."

In the open comments regarding the lectures, they seem to have worked as a complement to the readings.

"Having the text and the lectures makes the learning clearer, for instance if I had read something in a text and then the professor would talk about it it felt more understandable".

The teachers received over-all good grades, even though there was some variation. Some teachers' lectures were described as "amazing" whilst some got some remarks about un-clear structure or limited interactivity.

"Overall, I think the teachers did very good at the lectures. It helps when the teachers are passionate about the subjects, and everyone seemed to be that."

Regarding the literature it was mainly positively evaluated, but there were also some critical remarks:

"It was not consistent in how much to read for the relevant research areas, it fluctuated in quantity"

The seminars overall got a high score and the "bee-hive" structure seem to have worked well:

"I appreciate that seminars were student-led. Teachers overall very engaging and interactive with the students. I can only speak for my own seminar group (group 1), but I genuinely enjoyed the seminars."

"The seminars were great! I learnt a lot here."

Some commented that the seminars were "rushed" with too many presentations. This varied a bit between the seminars, and is due to the high number of students in recent years.

The examination with separate papers also received good scores, and positive comments:

"Good length - challenging to write papers every other week, but manageable at the end of the day."

There were some comments on different requirements for different papers, which should be discussed among the teachers.

"Some modules required more work than others this also increased the difficulty of writing some papers as opposed to others."

The organization of the course as well as the information was positively evaluated, even though the some comments was made regarding the group organization for the seminars.

"All information are very accessible and everyone answers emails in short period."

"The group organisation for the seminars was very confusing. I had a hard time understanding which group I belonged to and which seminar I was supposed to have a presentation in. This really needs to be addressed and made clearer."

Finally when it comes to the question of "eureka moment" many comments bear witness of several such moments.

"I had a lot of Eureka moments. each class and theme was very new. I loved to learn about the importance of bureacracy and lack of corruption that is now more important than the level of democratic election on the level of good government.."

The extra resource with a T/A in Academic writing has been valuable for many students, as the following quote illustrates:

"Excellent academic writing assistance! It gave me a lot of constructive feedback, which helped me improve my writing!"

"In hindsight, it would have been nice if you had stressed even more the importance of scheduling a meeting with the teacher assistant in academic writing. We all come from so different backgrounds where some have written a lot and others very little."

The extra resource in terms of assistance in Academic writing is valuable for the course, but the problem of reaching the weakest students should be addressed further.

To conclude, the course SK2121 Political Science Analysis is a well-functioning course that has found its form. Some criticism regarding variations within the course is unavailable with so many teachers involved but show the necessity of continued close communication within the teacher group. The extra resource provided by Elena Leuschner was very appreciated also by the teachers. The grading of all papers in short time is demanding, and when there has been some students lacking experience of academic writing, this has required a lot of extra individual tutoring. With the help from the T/A on Academic writing the students could get the extra need required, without putting extra load on the teachers.